8

Borderlands and Oceans

With a total length of nearly 3,000 kilometres, the Brahmaputra is one of the longest rivers of the world. It originates in the Angsi Glacier north of the Himalayas, and then flows for more than 1,620 kilometres through Tibet before it enters India and cascades down to the Assam plains. It then flows through Bangladesh, joins the Ganges and other rivers with which it forms a delta, and, finally, empties into the Bay of Bengal. The Brahmaputra, known as the Yarlung Tsangpo in Tibet and the Jamuna in Bangladesh, is the lifeline of tens of millions of people. There was, therefore, alarm in India when it became known in 2009 that China was building a 116-metre-tall and 389-metre-long dam to support a 540-megawatt power station at Zangmu in Tibet. The Chinese had until then denied that it had any plans to build a mega dam just north of India and Bhutan. In January 2013, the Chinese government approved the construction of three more dams on the river, at Dagu and Jiexu upstream and at Jiacha below Zangmu Dam. Altogether 28 dam projects in Tibet have been proposed.

Causing more alarm, Li Ling, a Chinese scientist, published a book called *Save China, Through Water From Tibet*[1] in November 2005 in which he mentioned that Chinese water experts had conducted a survey on the viability of transferring water from Tibet's rivers to central China to alleviate water shortage there.[2] Most of China's big rivers originate in the Tibetan highlands, and the idea to divert waters from the tributaries and actually reroute the Brahamputra to the Yangtze-Huang He, or the Yellow River, was not even new. The PLA had entertained such ideas at least since the 1980s.[3] Although 70 per cent of the waters of the Indian stretch of the Brahmaputra comes from direct rainwater collected south of the border and